

[Lesson 44](#): Being Good Citizens (See L44 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To encourage us to be good citizens by participating in government, obeying the law, and strengthening the community.

†1. President Ezra Taft Benson Why do you think Elder Benson was encouraged to accept such a responsibility?

1. Participating in government

• Read [D&C 134](#). In “August 1835, a general assembly of the Church at Kirtland, Ohio, unanimously approved a declaration of beliefs about government.” (*Lesson Manual*)

What are the purposes of civil governments? †2. Purposes of Civil Governments

What can we do as citizens to help fulfill these purposes of government?

†3. Elder L. Tom Perry

How can we support and defend truth, right, and freedom through our participation in government?

• D&C 134:3 and [98:10](#). We should seek leaders who “administer the law in equity and justice” (134:3).

What other qualities should we look for when choosing leaders? (See D&C 98:10.)

How can we prepare ourselves to choose leaders wisely? †4. The Church and Politics

2. Obeying the laws of the land

• See [D&C 58:21–22](#); [98:4–6](#); [134:5–6](#); [Articles of Faith 1:12](#).

What is our responsibility regarding the laws of the land?

How can parents, teachers, and leaders teach children to obey the laws of the land?

• See [D&C 134:3, 6](#). How should we treat law-enforcement officers and other civil officers?

How can we show our appreciation for their efforts?

• See [D&C 134:4, 9](#). What relationship should exist between religion and civil governments?

How can religion strengthen government? • Read “[I Spoke Out for Faith](#),” Nina Bazarskay, as told to Valerie Parker

3. Strengthening the community

†5. Members Civic Duty *Strengthen the Community*

What are some of the ways we can strengthen our community?

1. Serve others

Why is it important that Church members serve in their communities?

What are some community service projects that you or other Church members have participated in?

What are some individual, informal ways that you or other Church members have given community service?

What opportunities for service exist for our community today? How can we learn about these opportunities?

In what ways does community service benefit the community? How are we blessed as we serve?

2. Serve in elected or appointed public service positions

†6. Statement of the First Presidency

What are some examples of public service positions in our community?

How are people in such positions able to bring about good in a community?

3. Support worthy causes or activities

• Read [D&C 58:27](#). How can we become “anxiously engaged” in good causes in the community?

†7. Donald S. Conkey r.e. Dolina Smith

What are some worthy causes we can support in the community?

How can we appropriately fight evil influences in our community?

What are some challenges to serving in the community?

How can we overcome these challenges?

†8. Elder M. Russell Ballard †9. Ted L. Gibbons †10. Edmund Burke

Next Week: L45: “The Family Is Ordained of God”; See L45 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. President Ezra Taft Benson:

In “1952, while serving in the Quorum of the Twelve Apostles, Elder Ezra Taft Benson was asked by Dwight D. Eisenhower, President of the United States, to serve as the nation’s Secretary of Agriculture. With the encouragement of Church President David O. McKay, Elder Benson accepted the assignment and served well. In his first general conference address after becoming Secretary of Agriculture, he said:

“ ‘I have been happy in the privilege to serve, in a small way at least, this great country and the government under which we live. I am grateful to the First Presidency and my brethren that they have been willing, not only to give consent, but also to give me their blessing as I responded to the call of the chief executive’ ” (in Conference Report, Apr. 1953, 40 and in the *Lesson Manual*).

†2. Purposes of Civil Governments:

- a. “For the good and safety of society ([D&C 134:1](#)).
- b. “For the protection of the innocent and the punishment of the guilty” ([D&C 134:6](#)).
- c. “For the protection of all citizens in the free exercise of their religious belief” ([D&C 134:7](#)).
- d. “For redress of all wrongs and grievances” ([D&C 134:11](#)).

†3. Elder L. Tom Perry: “As Church members, we live under the banner of many different flags. How important it is that we understand our place and our position in the lands in which we live! We should be familiar with the history, heritage, and laws of the lands that govern us. In those countries that allow us the right to participate in the affairs of government, we should use our free agency and be actively engaged in supporting and defending the principles of truth, right, and freedom” (“[A Meaningful Celebration](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1987, 72).

†4. The Church and Politics: As “we participate in government and political processes, we should do so with the understanding that ‘the Church is politically neutral. It does not endorse political parties, platforms, or candidates. Candidates should not imply that they are endorsed by the Church or its leaders. Church leaders and members should avoid any statements or conduct that might be interpreted as Church endorsement of political parties or candidates’ ” (*Church Handbook of Instructions, Book 2: Priesthood and Auxiliary Leaders* [1998], 325). (*Lesson Manual*)

†5. Members Civic Duty: “Members should do their civic duty by supporting measures that strengthen society morally, economically, and culturally. Members are urged to be actively engaged in worthy causes to improve their communities and make them wholesome places in which to live and rear families” (*Church Handbook of Instructions: Book 2, page 325*). (*Lesson Manual*)

†6. Statement of the First Presidency: “We strongly urge men and women to be willing to serve on school boards, city and county councils and commissions, state legislatures, and other high offices of either election or appointment” (First Presidency letter, 15 Jan. 1998). (*Lesson Manual*)

†7. Donald S. Conkey: “While Dolina Smith was serving as Young Women president in the Toronto Ontario Stake in 1986, she asked an expert to speak at a fireside about the growing problem of [pornography](#). Later she became involved with a nationwide group called Canadians for Decency, which mobilizes thousands of anti-pornography Canadians to contact their elected officials as specific concerns about pornography arise. ...

“... In 1990 her involvement increased when she was named chairperson of Canadians for Decency. In this new role she has given numerous presentations before the provincial and federal governing bodies that make and change pornography laws. She has also spoken to many groups of citizens who work with local governments to clamp down on the spread of pornography in their communities” (Portraits, “[Together We Can Make a Difference](#),” *Ensign*, Feb. 1996, 68).

Recommended reading:

1. Elder M. Russell Ballard, “[The Effects of Television](#),” *Ensign*, May 1989, 80.
2. President Joseph F. Smith “[Chapter 14: Being Loyal Citizens](#),” *Teachings of the Presidents of the Church: Joseph F. Smith*, (2011), 122-127.
3. Lorentz C. Pearson, “[Citizenship: It’s a Grassroots Activity](#),” *Ensign*, June 1977.
4. “[Community Service](#),” at [mormon.org](#).

Visit [stephenmbird.com](#)

†8. **Elder M. Russell Ballard:** “In the Church, we often state the couplet, ‘Be in the world but not of the world.’ ... Perhaps we should state the couplet ... as two separate admonitions. First, ‘Be in the world.’ Be involved; be informed. Try to be understanding and tolerant and to appreciate diversity. Make meaningful contributions to society through service and involvement. Second, ‘Be not of the world.’ Do not follow wrong paths or bend to accommodate or accept what is not right. ...

“Members of the Church need to influence more than we are influenced. We should work to stem the tide of sin and evil instead of passively being swept along by it. We each need to help solve the problem rather than avoid or ignore it” (“[The Effects of Television](#),” *Ensign*, May 1989, 80).

†9. **Ted L. Gibbons:** “A careful consideration of the scriptural record will provide several accounts of members of the covenant people serving in positions of civil significance. Daniel and his three friends were political figures in Babylon (Daniel 2:48,49). Mordecai and his niece Esther were a part of the king's court in Persia (see Esther 2; Esther 8:2). Joseph became prime minister of Egypt, second only to Pharaoh in all the land (Genesis 41:39-41). Ezra Taft Benson served in the cabinet of President Eisenhower. Joseph Smith served a city Mayor of Nauvoo, and he campaigned for President of the United States. There are other examples. They all clearly demonstrate the interest of the Lord and his servants in the way his people and his children are governed.” (“[Being Good Citizens, D&C Lesson #44](#)” at [ldsgospeldoctrine.net](#)).

†10. **Edmund Burke:** “The only thing necessary for the triumph of evil is for good men to do nothing.” (In George Seldes, comp., *The Great Thoughts*, New York: Ballantine Books, 1985, p. 60 in Ted L. Gibbons “Being Good Citizens”).)

Further recommended reading:

1. Breck England, Lesson 44 “[Being Good Citizens](#),” at Meridian Magazine.
2. Nancy Jensen, at Gospel Doctrine Plus, in Doctrine and Covenants Lesson #44 “[Being Good Citizens](#).” She tells the story of Pat and Clyde Braegger, both in wheelchairs, who served their community.
1. Richard J. Mouw, “[What Does God Think about America? Some Challenges for Evangelicals and Mormons](#),” *BYU Studies*, Volume 43, no.4. A FREE – PDF Download is available.